placed real power in the hands of the curating institution. In Judaism the canonisation of the Old Testament and Mishnah went hand in hand with creating the institution of the rabbinate. In Christianity the canonisation of the New Testament went hand in hand with the creation of a unified Christian church. Christians trusted church officials – like Bishop Athanasius – because of what they read in the New Testament, but they had faith in the New Testament because this is what the bishops told them to read. The attempt to invest all authority in an infallible superhuman technology led to the rise of a new and extremely powerful human institution – the church.

THE ECHO CHAMBER

As time passed, problems of interpretation increasingly tilted the balance of power between the holy book and the church in favour of the institution. Just as the need to interpret Jewish holy books empowered the rabbinate, so the need to interpret Christian holy books empowered the church. The same saying of Jesus or the same Pauline epistle could be understood in various ways, and it was the institution that decided which reading was correct. The institution in turn was repeatedly shaken by struggles over the authority to interpret the holy book, which resulted in institutional schisms such as that between the Western Catholic Church and the Eastern Orthodox Church.

All Christians read the Sermon on the Mount in the Gospel of Matthew and learned that we should love our enemies, that we should turn the other cheek and that the meek shall inherit the earth. But what did that actually mean? Christians could read this as a call to reject all use of military force,[58] or to reject all social hierarchies.[59] The Catholic Church, however, viewed such pacifists and egalitarian readings as heresies. It interpreted Jesus's words in a way that allowed the church to become the richest landowner in Europe, to launch violent crusades and to establish murderous inquisitions. Catholic theology accepted that Jesus told us to love our enemies, but explained that burning heretics was an act of love, because it deterred additional people from adopting heretical views, thereby saving them from the flames of hell. The French inquisitor Jacques Fournier wrote in the early fourteenth century an entire treatise on the Sermon on the Mount that explained how the text provided justification for hunting